

Autonomy, Mastery, Purpose: The Science of What Motivates Us

By Maria Popova · The Marginalian

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The question of how to avoid meaningless labor and instead find fulfilling work brimming with a sense of purpose is an enduring but, for many, elusive cultural ideal. Daniel Pink tackles the conundrum in this wonderful animation by the RSA, based on his book *Drive: The Surprising Truth About What Motivates Us*.

Pink shares the counterintuitive results of two studies that reveal the inner workings of what influences our behavior — and the half-truth of why money can't buy us satisfaction:

Watch the animation: [RSA Animate — Drive \(youtube.com/watch?v=u6XAPnuFjJc\)](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=u6XAPnuFjJc)

"The best use of money as a motivator is to pay people enough to take the issue of money off the table: pay people enough so that they're not thinking about money and they're thinking about the work. Once you do that, it turns out there are three factors that the science shows lead to better performance, not to mention personal satisfaction: autonomy, mastery, and purpose."

In *Drive*, Pink illustrates why the traditional carrots-and-sticks paradigm of extrinsic reward and punishment doesn't work, pointing instead to his trifecta of intrinsic motivators:

- **Autonomy** — the desire to be self-directed.
- **Mastery** — the itch to keep improving at something that's important to us.
- **Purpose** — the sense that what we do produces something transcendent, or serves something meaningful beyond ourselves.

Also of note is Pink's TED talk on the subject: [Dan Pink on the puzzle of motivation \(TED\)](https://www.ted.com/talks/daniel_pink_the_puzzle_of_motivation).

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